

Chapter 108_2 - Flower Stem

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The last time she went to the underworld was already thirty years ago. Back then, she had transformed into a golden hamster, chattering noisily as she clung to Chu Qingqiu's shoulder.

But this time, stepping into the underworld and looking at the countless souls around her who were listless, having just been pulled from the mortal world, she couldn't stir up much emotion in her heart.

Only a touch of melancholy - no matter how glorious a person's life, after death they all had to bite their fingers in confusion, waiting to drink Meng Po's¹ bowl of soup.

The female judge who had brought her in carefully tugged at the rope on her body, smiling apologetically: "I say, demon lord, I've brought you in. Can you let me go now?"

Ning Fuyi sidestepped to avoid a ghost who had been torn apart by carts, and spoke: "You brought me in without asking who I am. Aren't you afraid I'll disrupt your underworld?"

"If it's disrupted, so be it. I'm just a ghost catcher who works through the night catching ghosts. How could I manage the affairs of you important people?" The ghost official had applied a face full of white makeup and spoke glibly. "Being able to avoid having my soul scattered is already my pursuit."

"You've calculated that I would release demonic energy here and then be devoured by fierce ghosts, haven't you?" Ning Fuyi sneered, having long seen through her little scheme.

But she didn't say much more, raising her hand to wipe the judge's memory, then bent down to avoid the ghosts that suddenly surged forward, silently stepping onto the Yellow Springs Road².

She maintained her composure while avoiding those ghosts, taking advantage of Meng Po's momentary distraction to pass the Naihe Bridge³, walking straight toward the lonely blooming, endless fields of red spider lilies⁴.

She accidentally touched a red spider lily, then nearly collapsed from the sudden sharp pain. She staggered a few steps out of the flower forest, the pain causing cold sweat to soak her clothes.

Lifting her hem, a deep wound visible to the bone appeared on her calf, blood flowing down her skin into her foot wrappings.

She tore off a strip of cloth from her clothes to bandage it, her heart going numb involuntarily. So just one wound could cause such pain - then the layers upon layers of marks on Chu Qingqiu's legs, wouldn't that pain pierce to the bone?

She was just raising her head when she suddenly narrowed her brows and stepped back. A person was sitting in the flower bushes beside her at some unknown time, and she hadn't noticed at all.

That person was a white-haired old man, his chin beard braided into a thick long plait that hung swaying on his chest. He was closing his relaxed eyelids, muttering unclear scriptures.

Ning Fuyi watched him warily for a while. Seeing that he didn't move, she clapped her hands across the sea of flowers to get his attention.

The old man opened one eye to look at her, but wasn't surprised. He closed it again and continued chanting.

This person had a solid body and cast a shadow - he didn't look like a ghost or spirit. So Ning Fuyi carefully avoided the red spider lilies and walked to his side, brazenly searching through his belongings.

Finally, she pulled out a small jade tablet from his beard, with the characters "Fengdu⁵" carved on it.

Emperor Fengdu? Ning Fuyi quickly jumped out of the flower sea, standing on the field ridge and looking at him in shock.

Emperor Fengdu was the ruler of the netherworld, with a lifespan equal to the gods. Counting back, he was also an ancestor from tens of thousands of years ago. She never expected to see a living one here, dressed so ordinarily.

If she hadn't looked at that jade tablet, he would have looked more like a flower farmer growing flowers here.

"Are all you girls from the immortal realm so rude?" Fengdu finally finished chanting and opened all his eyes, using his index finger to stuff the jade tablet back into his beard.

"I've disturbed you, senior. I only came to seek a flower." Ning Fuyi said. She looked around, but it was difficult to find the stem carved with her name that she had seen years ago in the now much denser flower sea.

Fengdu opened his eyes to look at her, then pointed into the distance with that index finger: "What you seek should be over there."

Ning Fuyi was about to walk over, then suddenly became alert: "How do you know who I'm looking for?"

"You're looking for yourself, aren't you?" Fengdu chuckled.

Ning Fuyi became even more puzzled. She pondered Fengdu's earlier words, then asked again: "You just said 'you girls' - does that mean besides me, someone else has come looking before?"

"Indeed so, but not from before." Fengdu stroked his beard and laughed, unfazed. "But from the future."

¹ **Meng Po (孟婆)** - In Chinese mythology, an old woman who serves a soup that erases memories of past lives to souls before they reincarnate

² **Yellow Springs Road (黄泉路)** - The path souls take in the underworld after death

³ **Naihe Bridge (奈何桥)** - The "Bridge of Helplessness" in Chinese mythology that souls must cross in the underworld, where they drink Meng Po's soup

⁴ **Red spider lilies (彼岸花)** - Flowers that bloom in the underworld, literally meaning "flowers of the other shore," associated with death and separation

⁵ **Fengdu (酆都)** - The legendary capital of the Chinese underworld, ruled by Emperor Fengdu